Blessing or a Curse

The law can save no one — it can only curse those who fail to keep it perfectly. God has always justified sinners as He justified Abraham: by faith alone. Christ became a curse in our place so the blessing of Abraham and the promised Spirit come by faith.

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Faith, its substitute, and its solution

Galatians 3:6–14 · The commentary's outline

I. The Study of Faith · vv.6–9

- Foundation — Abraham believed God (v.6)
- Fellowship — only those of faith are Abraham's sons (v.7)
- Fruit — the nations blessed by faith (vv.8–9)

II. The Substitute for Faith · vv.10–12

- Fabrication — a curse is tied to the law (v.10a)
- Obstruction — the law itself says the just live by faith (vv.11–12)
- Compensation — everyone is under the curse (v.10b)

III. The Solution of Faith · vv.13–14

- Christ became a curse for us (v.13)
- Christ bestowed the blessing — and the promised Spirit (v.14)

Abraham: the pattern for justification

Galatians 3:6–9 · Outline I — The study of faith

A **Foundation · v.6**

ἐπίστευσεν · ἐλογίσθη
Abraham believed; righteousness was credited to his account — not earned

B **Fellowship · v.7**

υἱοί
Only those of faith are sons of Abraham — whatever the family tree says

C **Fruit · vv.8–9**

προευηγγελίσατο
The gospel preached to Abraham beforehand: “In you all the nations shall be blessed” (Gen 12:3)

Then and now, God justifies the same way: by faith alone, apart from works.

Why the law can only curse

Galatians 3:10–12 · Outline II — The substitute for faith

A curse is attached	Keep all of it?	No one does	The law's own witness
κατάραν “Cursed is everyone who does not continue in all things” (Deut 27:26) *v.10*	“The man who does them shall live by them” (Lev 18:5) *v.12*	The weakness was in the people, not the law (Heb 8:7–8) *v.10*	“The just shall live by faith” (Hab 2:4) *v.11*

Everyone who does not keep the whole law is cursed — and no one has kept it. We are all under the curse.

“The just shall live by faith” — three times

Habakkuk 2:4 in the New Testament · Outline II.B

Romans 1:17

- Tells who the just are

Galatians 3:11

- Tells how the just shall live
- δίκαιος · ζήσεται — the believer's ongoing life of faith

Hebrews 10:38

- Explains what “by faith” means — introducing Hebrews 11

Even under the law, the law itself testified that righteousness comes by faith.

Christ became a curse for us

Galatians 3:13–14 · Outline III — The solution of faith

v.13a	“Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law”	**ἐξηγόρασεν** bought out of the slave market
v.13b	“having become a curse for us”	**γενόμενος** He became the curse in our place
vv.10, 13	Deut 27:26 and Deut 21:23 — the same word binds them	**ἐπικατάρατος** “cursed” — law's curse, Christ's curse
v.14a	“that the blessing of Abraham might come upon the Gentiles”	justification by faith, apart from law
v.14b	“that we might receive the promise of the Spirit through faith”	**ἐπαγγελίαν** received by faith, not works

Discuss and apply

Galatians 3:6–14 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What does it mean that righteousness was “accounted” to Abraham (v.6)? How does that differ from earning it?

2. In what sense did Christ “become a curse” for us (v.13), and what does “redeemed” (ἐξαγοράζω) add?

Apply

Resting in an Imputed Righteousness
Write down one place you're tempted to “earn” what God has given freely, and replace the striving with a prayer of thanks.

Refusing to Trade Good News for Bad News
When you share your faith this week, consciously keep the gospel free of add-on requirements.

In one line: The law can only curse; Christ took the curse so the blessing comes by faith.